

Discovery Reference

One shape underneath every problem — how to place a client's problem, show where the human stays in control, and scope it the same way every time.

Document: Internal discovery reference (evergreen)

Companion: Scoping Worksheet (separate fillable file)

Audience: VortexDeep — client-facing discovery

Version: v01

1. The three layers

What we solve · the problem map — Four groups, ten sub-processes — organised the way an owner thinks, by function and pain, not by tools.

- Communication & Customers — intake · support · scheduling
- Sales & Growth — pipeline · content · e-commerce
- Documents & Finance — document/data processing · finance & admin
- Operations & Insight — internal operations · reporting & analytics

How it's built · the primitive — Nearly every solution is the same shape (below).

Departments differ; the mechanics rarely do — so most work is adaptation from reusable blocks, not invention.

How it's delivered · the method — Six phases: Discovery → Scope → Solution → Build → Validation → Live. Written sign-off at each. A human approves — not full autopilot.

2. The primitive



Almost every solution is this shape. The only things that change between them are the dials below.

3. The dials that set effort & price

- **Trigger** — inbound event · scheduled · threshold-monitored
- **Decision classes / branches** — none · one · several · multi-dimensional (e.g. language × type)
- **Systems touched** — inbox · CRM · accounting · calendar · document store · data feed
- **Human gates** — drafted reply held for approval · internal notify · money / publish sign-off
- **Fan-out** — one input producing several drafts

Complexity tiers

Base	capture, route, file/log; little or no branching.
Base + triage	classify into a few classes + a drafted reply held for review.
Multi-branch	several decision points or checks before routing.

4. Two things that are always true

Approve-before-send — the human stays in control. That's the product, not a caveat — and usually the reassurance that closes the trust gap.

Everything ends in a log / file / index — quiet auditability by default, which sits well with Swiss/EU record-keeping habits.

5. Using this in discovery

- Place the problem on the map, then sketch the primitive back to the client in their own words — fast, visible alignment.
- Walk the five dials out loud; each answer is a scoping fact, not a guess (use the Scoping Worksheet).
- Point at the human gate explicitly — it's where “assistant, not autopilot” becomes concrete.
- If a request doesn't fit the shape — autonomous, real-time, heavy data science, or a big one-off migration — say so early.